

## Pitching—El Paso Necessity

# Rocky, Bridges, a Dodger Man, Wants Strong Fundamentals

**HOLTVILLE, Calif.** — Everett Lamar (Rocky) Bridges was "brought up" in the Dodger system, so it's only natural that he's trying to pattern his El Paso baseball team as a club that will be "strong in fundamentals, good pitching... and adequate running."

He's making progress in two of those fields, but may have to wait until just before the Texas League season before answering definite questions on the most important part — pitching.

### All-important Outs

Bridges took the El Paso reins this year from Chuck Tanner who was promoted to the parent California Angels' Triple-A team — Seattle. Bridges managed at San Jose, Calif., the last two years after serving as the Angels' Coach in 1962-63.

"We need the right kind of pitching in our park because of the fences, but when you get down to fundamentals, it's the support you get for that all-important out that will make it a solo homer... or a 3-run homer. When you come down to it, the man might never come up to hit the homer if you get the man out in front of him," Bridges said.

### Rodriguez Tops

Bridges has Aurelio Rodriguez tabbed for the hot corner. Rodriguez was signed out of the Mexican League and

impressed with the Angels in spring training. The shortstop will be Jim Vopicka, an Illinois U graduate who has shown great promise.

Vic LaRose, who saw brief service with El Paso last year, and Gordon Avery, drifted out of the Boston organization, are fighting it out for second base — the latter having a slight edge with the bat.

### Vets at Key Slots

Charles Vinson and Jim Spencer are veterans bidding for the first base slot — and one of them is bound to stick with Seattle. That means player-coach Larry Stubing will be in the outfield — occasionally taking over at first.

Don Wilkinson (19 circuits 50 RBI) hopes to make contact more often to fulfill his hope as a home run hitter. He batted only .241 last year, but 38 of his 113 hits were for extra bases. He'll be in the outfield with Stubing and Jarvis Tatum.

### Krug and Egan

Tatum is one of the products of Bridges' San Jose team, having notched an impressive .320 batting average last year. Others are Dennis Papke, the backup catcher, and Dan Keller, an effective righthanded hurler.

Catching seems secure with veteran Chris Krug — former

Tulsa player who was drafted out of the Cubs' organization, sharing honors with Tom Egan who polled 11 homers for El Paso last year.

### Two Coaches

The Angels, who purchased the El Paso franchise this year, have Fred Koenig managing the organization's Quad-Cities club in Davenport, Iowa, and Harry Dunlap as manager at San Jose.

Andy Cohen and Stubing are El Paso coaches and Pete Luther is the trainer.

## Unusual in Playoffs

Unusual Texas League playoff notes last year featured a grand slam homer by Arkansas' Larry Stubing against Austin; a steal of home by Amarillo's Dan Kern against Albuquerque and a pinch hit 3-run homer by Albuquerque's Ray Youngdahl — also against Amarillo.

## Extra-Base Champs

Extra-base champs for the Texas League in 1966 were Winston Llenas, El Paso, and Larry Stubing, Arkansas, in homers with 25; Willie Crawford, Albuquerque in triples with 14 and the twosome of Llenas and Leopoldo Posada, Amarillo in doubles with 28.